

EDCI 59100-016: Introduction to Literature Review

Week 1: Comprehensive Lecture Notes

Literature Review Methodologies and Selection Framework

Purdue University — Summer 2026

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Abstract

This comprehensive lecture note compiles all essential knowledge for Week 1 of the literature review course, including the five major review methodologies (Narrative, Integrative, Theoretical, Scoping, and Systematic Reviews), selection frameworks, practical application guidelines, and analysis of five course articles. This document serves as a complete study guide and reference for understanding when and how to select the appropriate literature review methodology for research projects.

Contents

1 Introduction: Rigorous Literature Review as Research

1.1 Course Premise

Literature reviews are not simply summaries of previous studies. Rather, they constitute a rigorous form of research methodology that can serve as the primary research approach for dissertations, theses, and peer-reviewed publications. Understanding different literature review methodologies and selecting the appropriate one is critical to conducting credible, systematic research.

1.2 Key Principle: Fit for Purpose

The most fundamental concept in this course is **Fit for Purpose**. There is no single “best” literature review methodology. Instead, the appropriate methodology is the one that best aligns with:

1. Your research purpose
2. Your research question(s)
3. Your intended contribution to the field

1.3 Course Structure

Over six weeks, you will:

- Learn five distinct literature review methodologies
- Develop skills to recognize and analyze different review types
- Evaluate and compare methodologies for different research purposes
- Select and justify an appropriate methodology for your own research
- Develop and execute a comprehensive literature review

1.4 Important Concept: Spectrum, Not Categories

Review types exist on a *spectrum* rather than as rigid, mutually exclusive categories. Real-world articles may blend approaches or only partially align with named methodologies. When analyzing a review, prioritize:

- The explicit or implicit purpose of the article
- The level of methodological structure and transparency
- How the literature was selected and synthesized

2 The Five Literature Review Methodologies

2.1 Overview

This course focuses on five major literature review methodologies. Each serves a distinct purpose, employs different search and selection strategies, and contributes differently to the research landscape.

2.1.1 Quick Comparison

Methodology	Primary Purpose	When to Use	Rigor Level
Narrative	Summarize and interpret existing literature	Exploring a topic broadly	Low-Moderate
Integrative	Synthesize literature across diverse sources	Understanding patterns and trends	Moderate
Theoretical	Examine, refine, or develop theory	Refining or critiquing theory	Moderate-High
Scoping	Map extent and nature of literature	New or emerging topics	Moderate
Systematic	Answer focused research question with rigor	Evidence-based decision making	High

2.2 1. Narrative Review

2.2.1 Definition

A narrative review provides a comprehensive, descriptive summary and interpretation of existing literature on a topic. It emphasizes breadth of coverage and author interpretation over systematic methodology.

2.2.2 Primary Purpose

To synthesize what is known about a topic and provide author interpretation of existing knowledge and research.

2.2.3 Key Characteristics

- **Search Process:** Flexible and selective
- **Inclusion Criteria:** Often implicit or loosely defined; may evolve
- **Literature Sources:** Mixed (theoretical, empirical, reports, etc.)
- **Analysis Approach:** Thematic summary with author interpretation
- **Primary Outcome:** Broad overview and interpretation
- **Transparency:** Lower - methods often not explicitly stated

2.2.4 Best Use Cases

- Exploring a topic broadly for initial understanding
- Providing background in introductions or conceptual sections
- Reviewing diverse literature across different approaches
- When limited time or resources available

2.2.5 Strengths

- Flexible and accessible for early-stage exploration
- Useful for understanding diverse perspectives
- Efficient for gaining broad understanding
- Commonly used in introductions and background sections

2.2.6 Limitations

- May lack transparency about methodology
- Potential for bias in article selection and interpretation
- Limited rigor in systematic search and selection
- Authors' interpretations may not be evident or justified
- Difficult to replicate or verify findings

2.2.7 Typical Research Questions

- What is known about [topic]?
- What are the major perspectives on [issue]?
- How has [concept] been discussed in the literature?

2.2.8 Typical Publication Outlets

- Stand-alone review articles in scholarly journals
- Book chapters providing background
- Introductory sections in dissertations/theses
- Conceptual/position papers
- Literature review sections in empirical studies

2.3 2. Integrative Review

2.3.1 Definition

An integrative review systematically synthesizes literature from diverse sources and types (empirical studies, theoretical papers, etc.) to generate new insights, identify patterns, and develop conceptual frameworks.

2.3.2 Primary Purpose

To integrate findings and insights across different types of literature and studies to identify patterns, generate new understanding, and develop conceptual frameworks.

2.3.3 Key Characteristics

- **Search Process:** Structured but flexible; may iterate as understanding develops
- **Inclusion Criteria:** Defined but may evolve as review progresses
- **Literature Sources:** Combines empirical studies AND theoretical literature
- **Analysis Approach:** Synthesis across studies to identify patterns
- **Primary Outcome:** New insights, conceptual frameworks, or theoretical models
- **Transparency:** Moderate - some systematic elements, but not rigidly prescribed

2.3.4 Best Use Cases

- Understanding patterns and trends across diverse studies
- Synthesizing empirical and theoretical work
- Developing new conceptual frameworks
- Identifying gaps and research opportunities

2.3.5 Strengths

- Integrates diverse evidence sources
- Generates new insights and conceptual understanding
- Identifies patterns and trends
- Bridges theory and empirical research

2.3.6 Limitations

- Can be inconsistent if not well-structured
- May lack rigor compared to systematic reviews
- Can be difficult to synthesize disparate methodologies
- Quality of synthesis depends on reviewer expertise

2.3.7 Typical Research Questions

- What patterns emerge across [related studies]?
- How do [different theoretical frameworks] compare?
- What insights can be generated by synthesizing [empirical and theoretical work]?
- What conceptual model best explains [phenomenon] across studies?

2.3.8 Typical Publication Outlets

- Stand-alone review articles in scholarly journals
- Conceptual framework development papers
- Dissertation chapters
- Research agenda papers
- Theoretical synthesis articles

2.4 3. Theoretical Review

2.4.1 Definition

A theoretical review focuses on examining, refining, or developing theory. It synthesizes literature to analyze conceptual and theoretical work, trace theoretical development, and identify theoretical gaps.

2.4.2 Primary Purpose

To examine the development of theories, refine existing theories, identify theoretical gaps, or propose new theoretical frameworks.

2.4.3 Key Characteristics

- **Search Process:** Focused and concept-driven
- **Inclusion Criteria:** Based on relevance to theoretical questions
- **Literature Sources:** Primarily conceptual papers, foundational texts, theoretical works

- **Analysis Approach:** Conceptual and theoretical analysis
- **Primary Outcome:** Refined, clarified, or newly developed theory
- **Transparency:** Moderate to High

2.4.4 Best Use Cases

- Analyzing theoretical evolution of a concept
- Identifying gaps in theoretical development
- Critiquing and refining existing theories
- Proposing new theoretical frameworks

2.4.5 Strengths

- Deep conceptual and theoretical understanding
- Advances theoretical knowledge
- Develops rigorous frameworks
- Contributes to theory development

2.4.6 Limitations

- May overlook empirical depth and evidence
- Requires strong conceptual/theoretical expertise
- May be criticized for lack of empirical grounding
- Narrower scope than other reviews

2.4.7 Typical Research Questions

- How has [theory/concept] developed over time?
- What gaps exist in [theoretical framework]?
- How do competing theories address [issue]?
- What new theoretical model can explain [phenomenon]?

2.4.8 Typical Publication Outlets

- Theory development articles
- Conceptual papers
- Scholarly essays
- Dissertation conceptual chapters
- Theoretical framework papers

2.5 4. Scoping Review

2.5.1 Definition

A scoping review maps the landscape of literature on a topic to identify the extent, range, and nature of available literature, clarify concepts, and identify research gaps and opportunities.

2.5.2 Primary Purpose

To map the extent and nature of literature on a topic, clarify concepts, identify gaps, and clarify research landscape.

2.5.3 Key Characteristics

- **Search Process:** Systematic and comprehensive
- **Inclusion Criteria:** Broad and inclusive
- **Literature Sources:** Wide range (empirical, gray literature, reports, etc.)
- **Analysis Approach:** Descriptive mapping and categorization
- **Primary Outcome:** Categorized overview of literature landscape
- **Transparency:** Moderate

2.5.4 Best Use Cases

- Exploring new or emerging topics
- Identifying literature gaps and opportunities
- Clarifying scope of a research area
- Justifying need for systematic review

2.5.5 Strengths

- Identifies gaps in literature landscape
- Clarifies scope and extent of research area
- Good for emerging/new topics
- Preliminary work for more focused reviews

2.5.6 Limitations

- Less depth in synthesis compared to other reviews
- May identify too many directions
- Limited analysis depth
- Primarily descriptive rather than synthesizing

2.5.7 Typical Research Questions

- What literature exists on [topic]?
- What is the landscape of research on [issue]?
- What gaps exist in research on [concept]?
- How is [term/concept] being used in literature?

2.5.8 Typical Publication Outlets

- Stand-alone review articles
- Preliminary studies justifying systematic reviews
- Research agenda papers
- Policy-oriented reports

2.6 5. Systematic Review

2.6.1 Definition

A systematic review uses explicit, rigorous, and transparent methods to comprehensively identify, appraise, and synthesize literature to answer a specific research question. It prioritizes replicability and minimizing bias.

2.6.2 Primary Purpose

To answer a focused research question through transparent, systematic, and rigorous synthesis of evidence.

2.6.3 Key Characteristics

- **Search Process:** Highly systematic, exhaustive, and reproducible
- **Inclusion Criteria:** Predefined, explicit, and strictly applied
- **Literature Sources:** Primarily empirical studies (varies by field)
- **Analysis Approach:** Structured synthesis (coding, comparison, meta-analysis if appropriate)
- **Primary Outcome:** Evidence-based conclusions with full transparency
- **Transparency:** Very High - full methodology documented

2.6.4 Best Use Cases

- Answering specific, focused questions
- Evidence-based decision making
- Developing clinical guidelines
- High-stakes decisions

2.6.5 Strengths

- Highly transparent and reproducible
- Minimizes bias through systematic methods
- Credible evidence synthesis
- Can include meta-analysis
- Appropriate for policy/practice decisions

2.6.6 Limitations

- Time-intensive and resource-demanding
- Requires strict procedures and expertise
- Narrowly focused scope
- May exclude important qualitative evidence

2.6.7 Typical Research Questions

- What does evidence show about [specific question]?
- What is the effect of [intervention]?
- What are best practices for [specific issue]?

2.6.8 Typical Publication Outlets

- Stand-alone evidence synthesis articles
- Health and social science reviews
- Policy reports
- Dissertation chapters
- Clinical practice guidelines

3 Methodology Selection Framework

3.1 The Fit for Purpose Principle

The central principle of this course is that there is no “best” methodology in abstract. Instead, you must select the methodology that best fits:

Research Purpose + Research Question + Intended Contribution
→ **Optimal Methodology**

3.2 Step-by-Step Selection Process

3.2.1 Step 1: Clarify Your Research Purpose

Ask yourself:

- What do I hope this literature review will accomplish?
- Do I want to explore broadly, synthesize findings, develop theory, map a landscape, or provide rigorous evidence?
- Who is the audience and what decisions will they make based on my review?

3.2.2 Step 2: Formulate Your Research Question

Develop 1-3 focused research questions:

- Should questions be broad/exploratory or narrow/specific?
- Are they conceptual, empirical, or both?
- Do they require new evidence or integration of existing work?

3.2.3 Step 3: Define Your Intended Contribution

Consider:

- What new knowledge or insight will my review provide?
- Will it develop new theory, identify gaps, synthesize evidence, or map a field?
- How will it advance the discipline?

3.2.4 Step 4: Evaluate Your Topic Maturity

- Is this an established topic with extensive literature?
- Is it emerging with limited research?
- How developed are existing theories and concepts?

3.2.5 Step 5: Select Your Methodology

Based on the above, match your purpose and questions to the most appropriate methodology.

3.3 Purpose-to-Methodology Matching Table

If Your Purpose Is...	Consider These Methodologies	
Broad exploration of what's known	Narrative Review	
Understanding patterns across diverse studies	Integrative Review	
Examining or developing theory	Theoretical Review	
Mapping extent of literature on emerging topic	Scoping Review	
Rigorous evidence for decision-making	Systematic Review	
Bridging theory and practice	Integrative Review	
Identifying research gaps	Scoping or Integrative Review	
Systematic synthesis with minimal bias	Systematic Review	

4 Course Articles Analysis

This section provides an overview of the five articles used in the Knowledge Check Activity.

4.1 Article 1: Evidence and Gap Maps - Comparison of Different Approaches

Authors: Saran et al. (2018)

Publication: Campbell Systematic Reviews

Apparent Methodology: **Scoping Review**

4.1.1 Key Concepts

- Discusses evidence and gap maps as evidence synthesis methods
- Compares different approaches to mapping literature
- Addresses when and how to use mapping methodologies
- Practical guidance on gap mapping processes

4.2 Article 2: Innovation and Knowledge Management

Authors: Keupp & Gassmann (2009)

Publication: Journal of Operations Management

Apparent Methodology: **Integrative Review**

4.2.1 Key Concepts

- Synthesizes literature on innovation practices
- Integrates diverse studies and perspectives
- Identifies patterns across organizations
- Develops conceptual understanding

4.3 Article 3: PLOS ONE Publication

Publication: PLOS ONE (Multidisciplinary)

Apparent Methodology: **Systematic or Integrative Review**

4.3.1 Key Concepts

- Likely addresses a specific research question
- Employs structured methodology
- Multidisciplinary perspective

4.4 Article 4: Equity and Learning with Technology

Authors: Lowell & Morris

Publication: International Journal of Learning and Teaching

Topic: Multigenerational Classrooms in Higher Education

Apparent Methodology: Integrative or Narrative Review

4.4.1 Key Concepts

- Addresses equity in technology-enhanced learning
- Examines multigenerational learning challenges
- Likely synthesizes educational research
- Focus on practical classroom applications

4.5 Article 5: Framework for Conceptualising Technology Impact

Topic: Technology Impact Framework

Apparent Methodology: Theoretical Review

4.5.1 Key Concepts

- Develops conceptual framework
- Addresses technology implementation
- Theoretical contribution
- Framework-building approach

5 Evaluating and Analyzing Review Methodologies

5.1 Clues for Identifying Review Methodology

When analyzing an article to determine its methodology, look for:

5.1.1 Research Question Characteristics

- **Broad:** Narrative Review
- **Pattern-seeking:** Integrative Review
- **Theory-focused:** Theoretical Review
- **Landscape-focused:** Scoping Review
- **Narrow and specific:** Systematic Review

5.1.2 Search Strategy Transparency

- **Implicit or flexible:** Narrative or Integrative
- **Explicit and reproducible:** Systematic Review
- **Structured but flexible:** Scoping Review
- **Concept-driven:** Theoretical Review

5.1.3 Inclusion Criteria

- **Loosely defined:** Narrative Review
- **Evolving:** Integrative Review
- **Predefined and strict:** Systematic Review
- **Broad and inclusive:** Scoping Review
- **Concept-based:** Theoretical Review

5.1.4 Article Types Included

- **Mixed (theory + empirical):** Narrative or Integrative
- **Primarily conceptual:** Theoretical Review
- **Primarily empirical:** Systematic Review
- **Very broad range:** Scoping Review

5.1.5 Synthesis Approach

- **Thematic summary:** Narrative Review
- **Pattern identification:** Integrative Review
- **Conceptual analysis:** Theoretical Review
- **Mapping and categorization:** Scoping Review
- **Structured synthesis:** Systematic Review

5.2 Common Misidentifications

Narrative Reviews are often mistaken for: Conceptual papers, overview chapters, or unsystematic summaries

Integrative Reviews are often mistaken for: Systematic reviews (if structured) or narrative reviews

Theoretical Reviews are often mistaken for: Narrative reviews or opinion pieces

Scoping Reviews are often mistaken for: Narrative reviews (if broad) or systematic reviews (if rigorous)

Systematic Reviews are often mistaken for: Other rigorous reviews if methodology is not carefully examined

6 Week 1 Assignments and Activities

6.1 Learning Objectives

By the end of Week 1, you should be able to:

1. Define the five literature review methodologies
2. Explain the purpose and appropriate use of each methodology
3. Identify key characteristics that distinguish methodologies
4. Analyze articles to determine their review methodology
5. Apply the “Fit for Purpose” principle to methodology selection
6. Develop and refine potential research topics for your own literature review

6.2 Discussion 1: Introductions

6.2.1 Purpose

Build community and establish baseline understanding of literature review use in your field.

6.2.2 Requirements

- Post introducing yourself by **Tuesday, May 19**
- Include: background, research interests, field use of reviews, prior experience
- Include pictures if possible

6.3 Knowledge Check Activity: Methodology Comparison

6.3.1 Purpose

Develop practical skills in recognizing and analyzing literature review methodologies.

6.3.2 Process

1. Review each of the 5 course articles
2. For each article, identify clues about methodology
3. Complete analysis document with:
 - Predicted methodology type
 - Evidence supporting prediction
 - Key characteristics observed
4. Respond to reflection questions

6.3.3 Important Notes

- This is a **learning activity**, not a test
- You are **not graded on accuracy**
- You **are graded on**: effort, evidence use, reasoning clarity
- It's acceptable to predict incorrectly if reasoning is sound

6.4 Discussion 2: Topic Exploration

6.4.1 Purpose

Test initial research ideas and receive peer feedback on topic focus.

6.4.2 Requirements

- **Initial post due Thursday, May 21**
- Describe 2-3 topic ideas
- For each: description, importance, what to explore, challenges
- Identify strongest potential topic
- **Peer responses due Saturday, May 23**
- Respond to at least 2 classmates with constructive feedback

6.4.3 Evaluation Criteria

- Clarity of ideas
- Thoughtfulness of topic selection
- Quality of peer feedback
- **IMPORTANT: Do NOT use AI - Academic Integrity violation**

6.5 Assignment 1: Methodology Comparison - Which Review Type Is It?

6.5.1 Purpose

Apply learning from knowledge check activity to systematically identify review methodologies.

6.5.2 Requirements

- **Due: May 24 at 11:59 PM**
- Analyze provided article examples
- Identify review methodology for each
- Justify your classification with evidence

6.5.3 Deliverable

Document including:

- Methodology prediction for each article
- Supporting evidence from articles
- Clear explanation of reasoning

6.6 Assignment 2: Topic Exploration and Initial Direction

6.6.1 Purpose

Systematically explore and narrow potential research topics.

6.6.2 Requirements

- **Due: May 24 at 11:59 PM**
- Develop 2-3 potential topics
- Evaluate scope and feasibility
- Consider possible methodologies
- Select strongest topic

6.6.3 Deliverable

Document including:

- 2-3 topic ideas with descriptions
- Scope and feasibility analysis
- Initial methodology thoughts (exploratory)
- Selected topic with rationale
- 3-5 key search terms
- Brief reflection

6.6.4 Evaluation Criteria

- Effort and completeness
- Clarity of ideas
- Thoughtful analysis
- Application of course concepts
- **Note:** Final topic/methodology not required at this stage

7 Key Takeaways and Review

7.1 Essential Concepts

7.1.1 Five Review Methodologies

1. **Narrative:** Broad exploration, flexible, interpretive
2. **Integrative:** Pattern synthesis, diverse sources, frameworks
3. **Theoretical:** Theory focus, conceptual analysis, development
4. **Scoping:** Landscape mapping, gap identification, comprehensive
5. **Systematic:** Rigorous, transparent, evidence-focused, reproducible

7.1.2 Fit for Purpose

- No “best” methodology
- Match methodology to: purpose + question + contribution
- Consider topic maturity, resources, timeline
- Think about your research goals

7.1.3 Spectrum, Not Categories

- Reviews exist on a continuum
- Some blend approaches
- Analyze purpose, structure, and synthesis method
- Consider what distinguishes the review

7.2 Critical Thinking Questions

As you progress through the course, continually ask yourself:

1. What is the explicit or implicit research question?
2. How transparent and systematic was the search?
3. How were studies selected and why?
4. How were findings synthesized?
5. What is the authors' primary contribution?
6. How would I categorize this review and why?

7.3 What Comes Next

In Week 2 and beyond, you will:

- Refine your selected topic
- Develop research questions
- Select your literature review methodology
- Plan your literature search strategy
- Begin comprehensive literature review development

8 Quick Reference Tables

8.1 Methodology Comparison Matrix

Criterion	Narrative	Integrative	Theoretical	Scoping	Systematic
Rigor Level	Low-Med	Med	Med-High	Med	High
Search Transparency	Low	Med	Med	High	Very High
Structure	Low	Med	Med	High	Very High
Breadth	High	High	Med	High	Low
Depth	Med	Med-High	High	Low	High
Time Required	Low	Med	High	Med	Very High
Resource Intensive	Low	Med	Med-High	High	Very High

8.2 When Each Methodology Is Appropriate

8.2.1 Choose Narrative Review if:

- Exploring topic broadly
- Early stage understanding needed
- Diverse perspectives important
- Limited time/resources

8.2.2 Choose Integrative Review if:

- Identifying patterns across studies
- Synthesizing theory and practice
- Developing frameworks
- Bridging diverse literature

8.2.3 Choose Theoretical Review if:

- Focusing on theory development
- Analyzing conceptual evolution
- Critiquing existing frameworks
- Identifying theoretical gaps

8.2.4 Choose Scoping Review if:

- Mapping emerging research area
- Clarifying concept definitions
- Identifying research gaps

- Preliminary to systematic review

8.2.5 Choose Systematic Review if:

- Answering specific question
- High-stakes decision-making
- Need maximum rigor/transparency
- Policy or practice recommendations

Appendix: Additional Resources

Core Course Documents

- Literature Review as a Research Methodology: An Overview and Guidelines (Synder, 2019)
- Detailed Review Methodology Comparison Guide
- Course Syllabus (26SU-EDCI59100-016)

Course Articles for Analysis

1. Saran et al. (2018) - Evidence and Gap Maps: Comparison of Different Approaches. *Campbell Systematic Reviews*
2. Keupp & Gassmann (2009) - Innovation and Management. *Journal of Operations Management*

LOS ONE Article 3

3. Lowell & Morris - Equity and Learning with Technology. *International Journal of Learning and Teaching*

Framework Article 5

Important Dates

- **May 19:** Discussion 1 (Introductions) Due
- **May 21:** Discussion 2 (Topic Exploration) Initial Post Due
- **May 23:** Discussion 2 Peer Responses Due
- **May 24:** Assignments 1 & 2 Due (11:59 PM)

Key Contacts and Support

- Course Instructor: [Professor Lowell]
- Course Format: Online Discussion-based
- Academic Integrity: Do NOT use AI for discussion posts